

The White Desert

A desert of chalk, shaped by wind-driven sand into an eerie landscape of stone monoliths



Often compared to a lunar landscape, the White Desert is located northeast of the oasis town of Farafra, Egypt. This gleaming terrain was originally an ancient seabed.

From chalk to chickens

When the prehistoric sea that once covered this vast area dried up, the bodies of millions of marine creatures calcified, forming an enormous plateau of chalk and chalky limestone. Millions of years of wind erosion carved the upland into pinnacles, spires, boulders, and other shapes—some so bizarre that they have been likened to giant mushrooms, ice cream cones, and even an oversized chicken. Occasionally, chalky inselbergs (isolated, towerlike hills jutting out of the flat plain) are also found among the smaller formations. The sand surrounding the shapes glitters with quartz crystals, adding to the White Desert's overall frosty appearance, particularly when viewed under moonlight.

▽ DESERT SCULPTURE

Windblown sand has carved these striking stone formations that seem to balance dangerously on severely eroded bases.



The Adrar Plateau

Mauritania's high, hot plateau, with a unique collection of desert landforms, and its own geological "eye"

The Adrar Plateau can be considered a miniature version of the Sahara Desert (see pp.208–209). With huge shifting sand dunes, rugged gorges, palm-filled oases, stone deserts, and rocky cliffs rising to about 790 ft (240 m) above their surroundings, this northwest African region has all the features normally associated with the Sahara as a whole. The center of the plateau, which lies in central Mauritania, is arid, with little to no vegetation, but enough water concentrates around the base of the surrounding uplands to allow the growth of some crops.

Desert eye

West of the Adrar, the plateau merges into the Richat Structure—a gigantic "bull's-eye" first noted from space. This geological dome, also known as the Eye of the Sahara (see p.209), is 25 miles (40 km) in diameter.



△ CUSTOM BILL

The greater hoopoe-lark uses its long, curved bill to probe for termites and other insects in the desert sands.

▽ TABLETOP MOUNTAINS

The dark tabletop mountains, or mesas, of the Adrar Plateau rise above almost barren sands.

